

Euripides  
HERAKLES  
[HERCULES FURENS]<sup>1</sup>

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TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

In numbering the lines in the following English text, the translator has normally included a short indented line with the short line immediately above it, so that two or three partial lines count as a single line in the reckoning. The line numbers in square brackets refer to the Greek text; line numbers without brackets refer to the English text. The stage directions and footnotes have been provided by the translator.

*Herakles* was first performed in Athens c. 416 BC.

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<sup>1</sup>Euripides' *Herakles* is also sometimes called *Hercules Furens*. If you use the latter title, be careful, because it is also the name of a play by the Roman Seneca.

# HERAKLES

## Dramatis Personae

AMPHITRYON: mortal father of Herakles, an old man.

MEGARA: wife of Herakles.

CHORUS: elderly citizens of Thebes.<sup>2</sup>

LYCUS: the new ruler of Thebes.

HERAKLES: son of Zeus.

IRIS: divine messenger of the gods.

LYSSA: goddess of madness.

MESSENGER: a servant in Herakles's house.

THESEUS: ruler of Athens.

SONS OF HERAKLES AND MEGARA: three young boys.

ATTENDANTS, SOLDIERS.

*[Outside the home of Herakles in Thebes. Amphitryon, Megara, and the three young sons of Herakles are sitting beside an altar to Zeus, where they have sought protection against Lycus, the new tyrant-ruler of Thebes. Behind the altar is the front door of the house or palace.]*

### AMPHITRYON

What mortal does not know about the man  
who shared his wife with Zeus? People call him  
Amphitryon from Argos. He was born  
some time ago to Alcaeus, the son  
of Perseus.<sup>3</sup> Amphitryon was father  
to Herakles, who lived right here in Thebes,  
where from the dragon's teeth that Cadmus sowed  
arose a harvest crop of earth-born giants.  
War god Ares spared a few of them,  
and their children's children now live in Thebes,  
city of Cadmus.<sup>4</sup> From them sprang Creon,  
son of Menoeceus and king of Thebes.  
He fathered Megara. Some years ago  
all the citizens of Cadmus' city  
escorted her, singing wedding songs,  
while flute music played, as splendid Herakles  
led her to my home. Later Herakles

10

[10]

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<sup>2</sup>Speeches assigned to the Chorus may be spoken or chanted by the entire Chorus or by individual members or partial groups of the Chorus or by a Chorus Leader, as a director of a production of the play will determine.

<sup>3</sup>Perseus, son of Zeus and the mortal woman Danaë, was an important traditional hero of Greek mythology, famous for slaying monsters (e.g., Medusa).

<sup>4</sup>Cadmus, from Asia Minor, founded Thebes in Greece. To create the city he had to kill a dragon and sow its teeth like seeds. When he did that, armed warriors arose out of the earth where the seeds had been. The earth-born warriors fought and killed each other, until the gods stopped the fighting. The surviving warriors thus became, along with Cadmus, the first citizens of Thebes.

## HERAKLES

moved away from Thebes, where I was settled,  
leaving Megara and her relations.  
He was eager to live in Argolis, 20  
a walled city built by the Cyclopes.<sup>5</sup>  
I had run away from there, an exile,  
because I had murdered Electryon.<sup>6</sup>  
So Herakles, to ease my punishment  
and keen to have a home in his own land,  
offered Eurystheus a rich reward,  
if he would permit me to return—  
he said that he would civilize the land [20]  
by getting rid of all the savage monsters.<sup>7</sup>  
Hera may have goaded him to do this, 30  
or perhaps his fate had turned against him.<sup>8</sup>  
The work he had to do was onerous,  
but he has finished all his tasks but one.  
To complete the final labour, he went through  
the mouth of Taenarus down to Hades,  
to drag that triple-bodied hound back up  
into the light.<sup>9</sup> He has not yet returned.  
Now, the Cadmeans tell an ancient tale  
about a man called Lycus, the husband  
of Dirce.<sup>10</sup> He was master of this city 40  
with its seven towers, before Zethus  
and Amphion, both sons of Zeus, who rode  
on milk-white horses, became kings of Thebes.<sup>11</sup> [30]  
His son, who has the same name as his father,  
was not from Thebes—he was a foreigner  
from Euboea. He murdered Creon,  
and after the killing ruled the country,  
for he had attacked the city at a time  
when it was suffering from civil strife.  
So our family's relationship to Creon 50

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<sup>5</sup>The Cyclopes were one-eyed monsters who worked for Zeus, making his thunderbolts.

<sup>6</sup>Amphitryon, Electryon's nephew, accidentally killed him when he threw his club at some cattle but missed and hit Electryon. Sthenelus, Electryon's brother, then seized the throne of Mycenae, charged Amphitryon with murder, and sent him into exile.

<sup>7</sup>Eurystheus was the son of Sthenelus, king of Mycenae. He set the twelve tasks that Herakles had to perform. Euripides departs from tradition here in stating that Herakles's motivation was to help out his human father, Amphitryon.

<sup>8</sup>In the traditional stories of Herakles, Hera, Zeus's wife, was a constant enemy of Herakles, because he was a bastard son of Zeus.

<sup>9</sup>Taenarus in the southern Peloponnese was a traditional entrance to the underworld. The triple-bodied dog was Cerberus, who guarded the entrance to Hades.

<sup>10</sup>Dirce was the daughter of the sun god Helios; the word is also the name of a river near Thebes.

<sup>11</sup>Zethus and Amphion were both mortal sons of Zeus.

## HERAKLES

will probably be very bad for us.  
For now my son is in some dark corner  
of the world below, the new king, Lycus,  
wishes to destroy Herakles's children,  
his wife, and me (as if my feeble age  
would still make me a man), so one blood feud [40]  
can be extinguished by another one,  
and these young boys will not grow into men  
who could seek vengeance for the slaughter  
of their mother's family. So my son 60  
left me in this house to rear his children  
and look after things, while he makes his way  
into the pitch-black darkness of the earth.  
I am sitting here at the altar of Zeus  
the Saviour with my son's wife, Megara,  
to help prevent the sons of Herakles  
from being murdered. My heroic son  
had this altar built to commemorate  
his splendid triumph over the Minyae. [50]  
We guard our seats here very carefully, 70  
for we are in need of everything—food,  
drink, and clothing—and we lie down to sleep  
on the bare cold earth. Our home is sealed shut,  
so we stay here in order to be safe.  
As for our friends, some of them, I notice,  
are uncertain, and others who are loyal  
find it impossible to offer us  
any further help. This is what men mean  
by being unfortunate. I hope that no one  
who feels even the least good will to me 80  
ever has to test this unerring proof  
of friendship.

## MEGARA

Old friend, who once led the army [60]  
of the Thebans to splendid victory  
by destroying the city of the Taphians,  
the ways gods deal with men are never certain.  
Look at me. Good fortune never ignored  
my father, and he was once considered  
an important man, because he was so rich  
and ruled the city. But most people crave  
wealth and power and like to throw long spears 90  
at those who are successful. My father  
had children, too. He gave me to your son,  
uniting me in a splendid marriage  
with Herakles. And now all that has gone—

## HERAKLES

it has flown away—and you and I, old man, [70]  
are going to die, and these children, too,  
the sons of Herakles, whom I keep safe  
underneath my wings, like a bird holding  
her chicks close to her. The boys question me,  
one after the other, “Mother, tell us, 100  
where has our father gone? What is he doing?  
When will he be back?” They keep on asking  
about their father—they are bewildered,  
as children often are. I change the subject  
or make up stories. But I am astonished  
whenever the doors creak, how they jump up,  
all eager to embrace their father’s knees.  
So now, old friend, what hope do we still have?  
What route to safety are you preparing? [80]  
For that I look to you. We cannot move 110  
in secret beyond the borders of this land,  
there are too many people watching us  
at the exit points, and we no longer  
have any hope of safety in our friends.  
Whatever you are planning, let me know,  
in case they are preparing for our deaths.

### AMPHITRYON

My daughter, it is not a trivial  
or simple matter to provide advice  
on things like this, not without hard work.  
Since we lack power to do anything, 120  
we should just delay.

### MEGARA

Do you want more grief? [90]  
Or are you still that much in love with life?

### AMPHITRYON

I rejoice in life, and I cherish hope.

### MEGARA

So do I, old friend. But you should not hope  
for something we have no right to expect.

### AMPHITRYON

The remedy for what is troubling us  
lies in delays.

## HERAKLES

MEGARA

But I find the time they take  
is painful—like a lingering bite.

AMPHITRYON

My daughter, there may be a useful way  
for you and me to escape the hardships 130  
we are facing now. My son, your husband,  
may still come back. So keep calm. Wipe the tears  
flowing from your children's eyes. Soothe their spirits  
with words—make up stories to divert them,  
even though such deceit is to be pitied. [100]  
For even human sufferings grow weary,  
and stormy winds do not retain their force  
forever, nor are successful people  
always prosperous to the very end.  
All things change from one thing to another. 140  
The finest men are those who always keep  
their hopes alive, and giving up all hope  
signifies the man who is a coward.

*[Enter the Chorus.]*

CHORUS

I have come here, to this high-roofed house  
and old man's resting place, propped up this way  
by my staff, chanting a mournful song, [110]  
like some old grey bird. I am just a voice,  
a dream vision of the night, a phantom,  
trembling with old age, but prepared to help.  
Ah, lads, you boys without a father, 150  
and you, old man and you, you poor mother,  
grieving for your man down in Hades' halls.

Do not let your heavy feet, arms, and legs  
give up, like a young horse under the yoke, [120]  
who slackens on a stony hill dragging  
a heavy burden in a four-wheeled wagon.  
Whoever feels his footsteps growing weak  
should hold someone else's hand or clothing.  
Let each old man help out another one,  
like when we were young and under arms, 160  
battle comrades toiling with new spears,  
so many years ago—we were no disgrace  
to our glorious native land!

## HERAKLES

Look at these boys!  
See how their father's spirit is flashing [130]  
in their eyes. His unhappy fortunes  
have not left these children unaffected,  
but they retain his graceful manliness.  
O Hellas, if you lose citizens like these,  
think of the kind of allies you will miss.

### CHORUS LEADER

But I see Lycus, king of Thebes, approaching— 170  
he is coming past the house.

*[Enter Lycus with attendants.]*

### LYCUS

I would like to ask a question, if I may, [140]  
to Herakles's father and his wife.  
Indeed, as your lord and master, I have  
a right to ask you what I wish to know.  
How long do you desire to prolong your lives?  
What hope or what assistance can you see  
that will rescue you from death? Do you believe  
the father of these children, who now lies  
in Hades, will return? You exaggerate 180  
your grief at having to die in a manner  
that is unworthy of you, a man who  
spread vain boasts throughout all Hellas that Zeus  
shared your marriage bed and was your partner  
in producing children, and you who say  
you are wife to the very best of men.  
But has your husband ever accomplished  
something notable? What if he did kill  
the hydra in a marsh or that monstrous lion 190  
of Nemea? He caught it in a snare,  
although he claims he seized it with his arms  
and strangled it. Are these stories the weapons  
you are going to use to fight against me?  
Is this the reason Herakles's children  
ought not to die? He has a reputation  
as a courageous man in his struggles  
with wild beasts, but these mean very little—  
for all other things he has no heart at all.  
He never strapped a shield on his left arm  
or approached a band of hostile spearmen. 200 [160]  
No. He fights with a bow, a coward's weapon,

## HERAKLES

always ready to run away.<sup>12</sup> The bow  
is no proof of manliness or courage—  
not like the man who stands and holds his ground  
and dares to face the flying spears, whose wounds  
can lacerate his flesh. What I am doing,  
old man, is not insolence but caution.  
For I am quite aware that I killed Creon,  
this woman's father, and occupy his throne.  
So I have no desire to see these boys  
grow into men and then take their revenge  
on me for the crimes I have committed.

210

## AMPHITRYON

Let Zeus defend his interest in his son.  
For my part, Herakles, it's up to me  
to show in what I say this man's ignorance  
about you. For I will not allow myself  
to listen to any man defaming you.  
First then, to call Herakles a coward  
is, in my view, a shameful use of words,  
an expression he never should have uttered.  
With the gods as witnesses, I must refute  
that allegation for you. I appeal  
to Zeus's thunder and the chariot  
Herakles was in when his winged arrows  
struck those earth-born Giants in the ribs,  
and with the gods he could then celebrate  
a splendid victory.<sup>13</sup> Or go to Pholoe,  
you despicable king, and ask that race  
of insolent four-legged Centaurs  
who they would judge the bravest man of all.  
They will say my son, the man you claim  
is just a charlatan.<sup>14</sup> And if you asked  
Dirphys in Euboea, your native land,  
it would not sing your praises. Why should it?  
You have never done a single noble deed  
to which your country could bear witness.  
Then you denigrate that clever instrument,

[170]

220

[180]

230

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<sup>12</sup>The Greek warrior tradition, as established in Homer, sometimes sees archers as less heroic than spearmen because the former fight at a distance from the enemy, whereas spearmen fight hand to hand.

<sup>13</sup>The Giants were immense monsters created by Ouranos and Gaia (Sky and Earth). They sought to wrest divine control from Zeus. Herakles was brought up to Mount Olympus to assist the Olympian gods, and he did so, by killing a number of Giants with his arrows.

<sup>14</sup>On Mount Pholoe, Herakles was attacked by a group of Centaurs driven mad by the smell of wine. He killed many of them with his arrows. A centaur was a creature with the head, arms, and torso of a human being and the body and legs of a horse.

## HERAKLES

the archer's bow and arrows. But come now,  
listen to me and learn a thing or two.  
A hoplite heavily armed becomes enslaved 240 [190]  
to his own weapons, and if those in the ranks  
are not brave enough, he himself is killed,  
thanks to the cowardice of his companions.<sup>15</sup>  
If he breaks his spear, he cannot protect  
his body from a lethal wound, for he has  
only one way he can defend himself.  
A man who holds a bow whose aim is true  
only has one weapon, but it is the best.  
By shooting countless arrows at other men  
he protects his body and does not die. 250  
He keeps his distance and holds the enemy  
in check. They stay on watch, but his arrows  
are invisible and inflict harsh wounds.  
He remains hidden from his enemies [200]  
but constantly on guard—and this tactic  
is by far the wisest course in battle,  
to hurt the enemy and protect yourself,  
without relying on chance. These arguments  
of mine are the opposite of your own  
concerning the matter we were discussing. 260  
Now, why do you wish to kill these children?  
What have they done to you? I will concede  
that in one way you are acting prudently—  
being yourself a coward, you are afraid  
of a noble man's descendants. That fear  
is hard on us, if your craven nature [210]  
means we have to die. We are your betters  
and would have made you suffer, if Zeus  
had been more righteous in his heart to us.  
But if you wish to hold onto the sceptre 270  
of this land, then let us leave as exiles,  
and do not act with violence, or else  
you yourself will have to suffer violence,  
when gods change the winds of your good fortune.  
Now, land of Cadmus, I turn to you, as well,  
with words of condemnation and abuse.  
Is this the way you defend Herakles  
and his children, the man who all alone  
moved to fight those Minyans in battle [220]

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<sup>15</sup>A hoplite was a well-armed infantryman, who usually fought alongside other hoplites. His weapons were typically a spear and a shield (and sometimes a sword). Richer hoplites were sometimes equipped with body armour and a helmet.

## HERAKLES

and gave a glimpse of freedom to the Thebans?<sup>16</sup> 280  
I will not praise Hellas, nor will I ever  
remain silent about her wretched conduct  
towards my son. She should have marched to Thebes  
to help out these young boys, bringing with them  
fire and spearmen and warrior armour,  
to pay him back for all his weary labours  
in ridding the land and sea of monsters.  
But, my child, neither the Theban city  
nor Hellas is now offering any help.  
You look to me, but I'm a feeble friend, 290  
nothing now but just a chattering tongue.  
The muscle I once used to have is gone, [230]  
my limbs tremble with old age, and my strength  
has disappeared. If I were young again  
and my body still retained its power,  
I would have grabbed my spear and sprinkled blood  
on Lycus's blond locks. I could watch him flee  
beyond the realm of Atlas, in terror  
of my spear.<sup>17</sup>

## CHORUS

Though often slow to start,  
the best men have good reasons to speak out. 300

## LYCUS

Use whatever lofty language you desire  
when you talk about me. I will respond  
to your fine words with unwelcome actions.

*[Turning to his attendants]*

You there, go to Helicon, and you others [240]  
to the forest on Parnassus. Once there,  
tell the woodsmen to cut down logs of oak.  
Then bring the timber back into the city.  
Pile it around this altar, front and back,  
set it alight, and burn them all alive,  
so they can understand this fact—the dead 310  
no longer rule this land. I am now its king.

*[Turning his attention to the Chorus.]*

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<sup>16</sup>Hercules had assisted Creon, king of Thebes, by defeating the Minyans, who had been collecting tribute from Thebes. Creon then offered Herakles his daughter Megara in marriage. The Minyans were a race of proto-Greek-speakers who settled in parts of Greece.

<sup>17</sup>The "realm of Atlas" is the extreme western end of the Mediterranean.

## HERAKLES

And you old men, who oppose my judgment,  
you will be moaning not only for these sons  
of Herakles but also for new troubles  
in your home. And then you will remember [250]  
that I am king and you are merely slaves.

CHORUS [*spoken by different individuals*]

You offspring of the earth, once sowed by Ares,  
after he had hacked out all the teeth  
in the dragon's ravenous jaws, why not  
raise the staff you have in your right hand 320  
and hit this heathen fellow on the head  
and make him bleed? He is not from Thebes—  
and that's a great disgrace, a foreigner  
ruling younger men. But you will never get  
much joy from being my lord and master.

Nor will you ever take what my hands earned  
after much hard work. You should go back [260]  
to where you came from. Maltreat people there.  
As long as I'm alive, you will never kill  
the sons of Herakles. And he is not hiding 330  
so far beneath the earth that he's abandoned  
his own sons.

Since you now possess this land  
which you have ruined, Herakles, our helper,  
has not received the recognition he deserves.

Should I work hard to assist my friends  
once they die, when friends are needed most?

O right hand, how you yearn to grip a spear,  
but your lack of strength saps my desire,  
or else I'd have stopped you calling me a slave [270]  
and would have made a splendid governor 340  
of Thebes, a post you now enjoy. A city  
sick with civil strife and evil counsel  
does not think properly. If it did,  
it would never take you as its master.

MEGARA

Old friends, I commend you, for it is right  
that friends should feel a justified resentment  
on behalf of those they love, but do not  
provoke the tyrant by arguing our cause  
in case he makes you suffer. Now, Amphytryon,

## HERAKLES

listen to what I think—you may find something 350  
 in what I have to say. I love my children.  
 How can I not love the ones I bore [280]  
 and for whose sake I have worked so hard?  
 I consider death a horrifying thing,  
 but men who fight against necessity  
 are, in my view, foolish. Since we must die,  
 let us not be eaten away by fire,  
 while our enemies laugh at us—to me  
 that is a dishonour far worse than death.  
 In many things, we must act with honour— 360  
 that is a debt we owe our families.  
 You are a splendid warrior—you have  
 your reputation—so for you to die  
 a coward's death is just not feasible.  
 My famous husband needs no witnesses [290]  
 to prove that he would never wish to save  
 these children if it meant that they would then  
 be labeled cowards. For the nobly born  
 suffer from the shaming of their children.  
 And I must not refuse to emulate 370  
 my husband's actions. Now think about this—  
 I have considered what you are hoping for.  
 Do you think your son will come home to Thebes  
 from the world below? Who has ever returned  
 from the dead and made it back from Hades?  
 Or could you mollify this man Lycus  
 with soothing words? Surely not. One should run  
 from stupid enemies and yield to those  
 who are well bred and wise, for with such men, [300]  
 if you behave with proper modesty, 380  
 you can easily draw up a friendly truce.  
 I have already pondered the idea  
 that if we were prepared to plead our case,  
 he might send the children into exile.  
 But what a wretched life—save them from death  
 and then leave them in abject poverty.  
 There is a saying that the face of hosts  
 looks with pleasure at their exiled friends  
 for just one single day. So have the grace  
 to die with us, since whatever happens, 390  
 death is waiting for you. I challenge you,  
 old man, by your nobility of birth,  
 for whoever struggles against a fate  
 set by the gods is a passionate man, [310]  
 but his passion is insane, for no one  
 can ever interfere with what must be.

## HERAKLES

### CHORUS

If my arms had any strength and a man  
insulted you, I would have no trouble  
stopping him. But now I have no power.  
So from this point on you, Amphitryon,  
must look for ways to evade misfortune.

400

### AMPHITRYON

It is not cowardice or love of life  
that hinders me from dying. I prefer  
to save the children of my son. It seems  
I am in love with the impossible.

*[Turning his attention to Lycus.]*

Look! Here is my neck ready for your sword—  
stab me, kill me, or hurl me from the rocks.  
I'm begging you, my lord, to grant both of us  
one favour—kill me and this poor mother  
before you slay the children, so that we  
are spared that horrific sight, as the boys  
gasp out their final breath, while calling for  
their mother and their father's father.  
As for all the rest, do whatever you wish.  
We have no way to save ourselves from death.

[320]

410

### MEGARA

I am also begging you to grant us  
one more favour, so that you will make  
the two of us doubly indebted to you.  
Allow me to change my children's clothing  
and dress them appropriately for death,  
by opening the house—at the moment  
we are locked out—so that the three of them  
at least get something from their father's home.

420

[330]

### LYCUS

That I will allow. I'll tell my servants  
to unbolt the doors. Go inside and dress.  
I will not begrudge you your fine garments,  
but as soon as you have decked your bodies,  
I will be back to ship you off to Hades.

*[Exit Lycus with his attendants.]*

### MEGARA

Children, follow the unhappy footsteps

## HERAKLES

of your mother into your father's house. 430  
Other people now own his possessions,  
but we still have his name.

*[Megara and the children enter the front doors of the house.]*

### AMPHITRYON

O Zeus,  
sharing my marriage bed with you now seems  
quite futile, and futile, too, was calling you [340]  
a partner in the fathering of my son.  
For you are less a friend than you appeared.  
You are a powerful god, and yet I,  
a mortal, am more virtuous than you—  
for I did not forsake the sons of Herakles.  
You were able to sneak into my bed 440  
and have sex with the wife of someone else,  
without the man's consent, yet you cannot  
come to the aid of friends and family.  
Either you are a truly stupid god,  
or else you are by nature quite unjust.

*[Amphitryon exits into the house.]*

### CHORUS

After a song of joyous prosperity,  
Phoebus is singing his own lament  
for beautiful Linus, who is dead, [350]  
strumming the strings of his lyre  
with a golden plectron.<sup>18</sup> But I wish 450  
to chant my praises for the man  
who has gone down to darkness  
beneath the earth—a child of Zeus,  
I call him, or of Amphitryon—  
a crowning celebration of his labours,  
for the excellence of his noble toil  
is a glorious tribute to the dead.

First, in Zeus's sacred grove  
he killed the lion and wore [360]  
the tawny skin along his back 460

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<sup>18</sup>Linus (or Linos) was a son of Phoebus Apollo. There are differing stories about him. In one, Linus is Herakles's music teacher. He tries to correct Herakles, and Herakles kills him.

## HERAKLES

with his fair head thrust in the gap  
of the fearful gaping jaws.<sup>19</sup>

Once his lethal flying arrows killed  
the ferocious race of mountain centaurs.  
The lovely eddies of Peneus's stream  
know him well and those far fields  
that lie unharvested, the farms  
on Pelion and the near-by caves [370]  
of Homole, the place from where  
the centaurs rode, with torches 470  
in their hands, to conquer Thessaly.

Then he killed the dappled deer  
whose horns were made of gold,  
the dreadful scourge of rustic farmers,  
and tribute to the goddess Artemis.<sup>20</sup>

He rode out in a four-horse chariot, [380]  
and with an iron bit he tamed  
Diomedes' horses, who ate  
in their stables stained with blood,  
their gory jaws devouring with joy 480  
the flesh of human beings, to sate  
voracious man-eating appetites.<sup>21</sup>  
Then he moved across the banks  
of the silvery Hebrus stream,  
still working for the tyrant of Mycenae.<sup>22</sup>

And on a headland near Mount Pelion,  
close to Anaurus' flowing stream, [390]  
he slaughtered Cynus with his arrows,  
a savage man dwelling in Amphanae,  
who murdered all his guests. 490

He came to the singing maidens  
and their orchard in the distant west,  
and once he killed the dragon there,

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<sup>19</sup>For his first labour, Herakles had to kill a lion whose skin was invulnerable. Herakles tried using his arrows, but they could not pierce the animal's skin. So Herakles strangled the lion with his bare hands.

<sup>20</sup>For the third labour, Eurystheus ordered Herakles to bring him the sacred deer of Ceryneia, a creature with golden horns. Herakles wounded the animal and carried it back alive to Eurystheus's palace, a distance of about fifty miles.

<sup>21</sup>For his eighth labour, Herakles had to capture the man-eating horses of Diomedes. Herakles killed Diomedes and brought the horses back to Eurystheus, who let them go.

<sup>22</sup>The tyrant of Mycenae was Eurystheus, who set the labours Herakles was to perform.

## HERAKLES

whose giant crimson coils twisted  
around the tree and guarded it,  
then from the leaves of gold  
and apple-bearing boughs  
he plucked the golden fruit.<sup>23</sup>  
He moved on to the Adriatic sea  
and calmed the waves for mortal men  
who row their ships across the waves.

[400]

500

He came to the domain of Atlas  
and, stretching up his arms,  
held up the central part of heaven,  
and on his manly shoulders bore  
the starry palaces of the gods.<sup>24</sup>  
Then he sailed through stormy waters  
of the Euxine sea against the mounted force  
of Amazons living around Maeotis,  
a lake which many rivers feed.  
He had gathered a group of friends  
from Hellas to steal from the warlike queen,  
Hippolyta, her gold-flecked warrior belt.  
Hellas completed the dangerous task,  
capturing the glorious garment  
of the barbarian queen and now  
in the city of Mycenae it is secure.<sup>25</sup>

510 [410]

Then he burned to ashes the hydra,  
a murderous many-headed watchdog,  
in Lyrna, and smeared its poison  
on the arrows with which he killed  
the triple-bodied shepherd Geryon  
a monster who tormented Erytheia.<sup>26</sup>

[420]

520

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<sup>23</sup>For his eleventh labour, Herakles had to bring back to Eurystheus some golden apples of the Hesperides (nymphs of the west, daughters of Atlas), which were in an orchard guarded by a large dragon.

<sup>24</sup>When Herakles was on his quest to find the golden apples of the Hesperides, he met Atlas, who tricked Herakles into holding up the heavens to separate them from earth. Herakles then tricked Atlas in turn in order to transfer the burden of holding up the sky back to Atlas.

<sup>25</sup>In his ninth labour for Eurystheus, Herakles had to bring back the girdle or warrior belt of Hippolyta, the queen of the Amazons (a society of female warriors, whose fighting skills matched those of men). The Euxine sea is now called the Black sea.

<sup>26</sup>Killing the Lernaean hydra was Herakles's second labour. The hydra was a many-headed monster. If someone chopped off one of the heads, two new heads grew in its place. Herakles solved that problem by chopping off a head and burning the place where the new heads were supposed to grow. For his tenth labour Herakles had to bring the cattle of Geryon (a triple-bodied monster) back to Eurystheus. Herakles killed Geryon with arrows poisoned with the blood of the hydra and, after going through a number of great difficulties, led the cattle back.

## HERAKLES

And in many other glorious tests  
you were successful. Now you have sailed  
to tearful Hades, your final labour,  
where you are finishing your life of toil  
and will not come back again. Now your house  
is bereft of friends, and Charon's boat  
awaits your sons on that godless, unjust path  
out of this life, with no hope of return.<sup>27</sup> 530  
Your house is looking to you for help,  
although you are not here in Thebes.

If I were young again with all my strength,  
and brandishing my spear in battle,  
with my young Theban comrades by my side,  
I would have stood with courage by your sons.  
But now my blessed youth lies in the past. [440]

*[Amphitryon, Megara, and the children enter from the front door of the palace.]*

### CHORUS

But I see the children of Herakles,  
who was so powerful in earlier days, 540  
all dressed up in clothing of the dead,  
with his loving wife leading her sons  
as if tied up together. There's the old father  
of Herakles. This is too much for me—  
I cannot stop the tears from welling up  
in both my ancient eyes. [450]

### MEGARA

Here we are.  
What priest or butcher will now put to death  
these unhappy children and end my life?  
The sacrificial victims are prepared  
to be escorted down to Hades' home. 550  
O my children, what an strange group we are  
being led away to die—old man, young boys,  
and mother, all together. What a sad fate  
for me and for my sons. This is the last time  
my eyes will see them. I gave birth to you  
and raised you so that our enemies  
could mock, humiliate, and murder you.  
Alas! How much all the things I hoped for [460]  
have disappeared, the expectations raised  
from what your father said.

---

<sup>27</sup>Charon was the boatman who rowed dead people across the river Styx into Hades.

## HERAKLES

*[Megara now speaks to each of her sons in turn]*

Your dead father  
wanted you to have command of Argos  
and live in the home of Eurystheus,  
with power over rich fruit-bearing lands  
in Thessaly. He would have liked to throw  
that lion's skin over your head, the one  
he used himself to protect his body.

*[Turning to the second son]*

And you were to be king of Thebes, a city famous for its chariots, and to receive as your inheritance your mother's land—you begged your father to do that for you. 570 And as a joke he put in your right hand [470] that cunningly carved club he used to use as his defence.

*[Turning to the third son.]*

And to you he promised  
to give Oechalia, which he ravaged  
with his arrows years ago.

*[Speaking to all the children]*

Your father  
 wanted to ennoble his three children  
 with three lands to rule—he was planning  
 great things for when you reached maturity.  
 Meanwhile, I was choosing brides for you,  
 striving to forge family connections 580  
 with Athens, Thebes, and Sparta, so that you  
 might have a prosperous life with your ship  
 securely anchored by cables at the stern.  
 All that has disappeared. Your fortunes [480]  
 have changed and are giving you as brides  
 the goddesses of death instead. My tears  
 will be your wedding bath. When I think of that  
 I feel so miserable. Your grandfather  
 considers Hades father of the brides  
 and is taking on the duties of a father— 590  
 he will celebrate the marriage feast.  
 Alas, which one of you will be the first  
 I hold against my breast? Which one the last?

## HERAKLES

Which one shall I kiss or hold close to me?  
I wish that, like the bees with humming wings,  
I could collect all my sighs together,  
blend them into one, and shed them in a tear.  
O my dearest Herakles, if the voice [490]  
of any mortal being can be heard  
in Hades, I am calling out to you— 600  
your father and your sons are going to die,  
and I, too, will perish. Once, thanks to you,  
people thought me very fortunate.  
Come and help us. Show yourself to me,  
even if you are a shade or just a dream.  
That will be enough, for these murderers  
of your children are all such craven fools.

## AMPHITRYON

Lady, prepare the rites for the world below.  
O Zeus, I hold up my arms to heaven  
and call on you—if you are intending 610  
to help these children, then protect them now,  
for soon all help from you will be in vain. [500]  
And yet we have prayed to you so often.  
The work I do is useless. It seems  
that nothing can prevent their deaths.

*[Amphitryon turns his attention to the Chorus.]*

Old friends,  
the business of this life does not last long,  
so you should pass through it as pleasantly  
as possible, with no suffering or grief  
from morning until night. Time does not care  
about keeping hopes alive. He stays busy 620  
with his own concerns, then flies away.  
Look at me—someone who was admired  
by all men for notable achievements—  
yet fortune has now taken that away  
in a single day, just like a feather [510]  
that floats off in the breeze. I do not know  
any man whose great wealth and reputation  
are secure. Farewell, my friends. You have seen  
your dear companion for the final time.

*[Megara sees Herakles approaching.]*

HERAKLES

MEGARA

Ah! Old friend, am I really looking at  
my husband? What can I say? 630

AMPHITRYON

I do not know,  
my daughter. I am lost for words.

MEGARA

This is the man who we were told  
was underneath the earth, unless it is  
a dream we are witnessing in daylight.  
What am I saying? I feel so anxious.  
What kind of vision am I looking at?  
Old man, this is none other than your son!  
Come here, children, cling to your father's robe. [520]  
Go quickly—and don't let go—for this man 640  
will protect you just as well as Zeus.

*[Enter Herakles. The children run over to him and clutch his clothing.]*

HERAKLES

Greetings to my home, to my gates and hearth!  
How glad I am to see you once again,  
now that I have come up into the light.  
Just a moment! What is going on here?  
I see my sons standing outside the doors  
dressed in robes of death, with garlands wrapped  
around their heads, and in that crowd of men,  
my wife and father weeping. What is wrong?  
I'll move up closer to them and find out.

*[Herakles moves over to Megara and Amphitryon.]*

Lady, 650  
what new disaster has fallen on our house? [530]

MEGARA

O you dearest of all men . . .

AMPHITRYON

O ray of light  
shining for your father . . .!

MEGARA

You have come back  
safe and sound, in time to save your family.

## HERAKLES

HERAKLES

What are you talking about? Father,  
what difficulties have I come home to?

MEGARA

We are going to be killed. Forgive me,  
my old friend, if I preempt your right  
to be the first to tell him about this.  
Females are perhaps more sensitive than men,  
and he was going to slay my children  
and I, too, was about to face my death.

660

HERAKLES

By Apollo, what an introduction  
to your story!

MEGARA

My brothers are dead  
and my old father.

HERAKLES

How did that happen?  
Who did it? Whose spear struck him down?

[540]

MEGARA

It was Lycus, the new king of Thebes,  
who killed him.

HERAKLES

Was everybody fighting?  
Was Thebes infected with sedition?

MEGARA

Yes, with civil war. Now he holds power  
in seven-gated Thebes.

670

HERAKLES

Why are you  
and my old father so terrified?

MEGARA

Lycus was going to kill your father  
and the children and me, as well.

HERAKLES

What are you saying?  
Why was he afraid of my orphan boys?

HERAKLES

MEGARA

He worried they might one day seek revenge  
for Creon's death.

HERAKLES

Why are the children wearing  
these clothes, as if they are preparing  
for the world below?

MEGARA

We have put on these robes  
to dress for our own deaths.

HERAKLES

Were you being forced  
to dress for your own deaths? That's horrible! 680 [550]

MEGARA

Our friends have disappeared, and we were told  
that you had died.

HERAKLES

Where did the idea  
that I was dead come from?

MEGARA

There were heralds  
from Eurystheus—they announced it.

HERAKLES

Why did you abandon my hearth and home?

MEGARA

We were forced to. Your father was dragged  
out of his bed.

HERAKLES

Did Lycus not feel shame  
dishonouring an old man like that?

MEGARA

Lycus and goddess Shame live far apart. 690

HERAKLES

Did I have no friends, when I was far away?

## HERAKLES

MEGARA

What man in misfortune has any friends?

HERAKLES

Have they forgotten how much I went through  
in those battles with the Minyans?

[560]

MEGARA

To repeat what I just told you, misfortune  
has no friends.

HERAKLES

These reminders of the world below  
take them off your heads. Look up at the daylight.  
Instead of the darkness of the underworld,  
let your eyes linger on the friendly sky.  
But now my hands have work to do in Thebes.  
First, I will go and totally demolish  
this new tyrant's home. Then I will hack off  
the ungodly villain's head and hurl him  
to the dogs to rip apart. If I find  
any Theban who has acted badly  
after all the good things I have done for him,  
I will smash him with my all-conquering club.  
With my feathered arrows I will destroy them  
and fill Ismenus full of bloody corpses,  
and Dirce's crystal stream will run blood red.  
Who should I protect more than my wife,  
my children, and my father? Farewell then  
to all my labours! That toil was futile.  
I should have been protecting my own sons  
and been prepared to die to keep them safe,  
since they were all about to suffer death  
because of their own father. Will we say  
it is a noble act to fight the hydra  
and that lion for king Eurystheus,  
if I do not fight hard to save my sons  
from being killed? I will no longer have  
that splendid name I had in earlier days—  
"Herakles the Glorious Conqueror."

700

[570]

710

[580]

720

CHORUS

It is right for parents to help their children,  
their aged fathers, and the ones they marry.

AMPHITRYON

My son, it is in your nature to love

## HERAKLES

your family and hate your enemies.  
But do not act too rashly.

HERAKLES

Father,  
how am I being more hasty than I should?

AMPHITRYON

King Lycus has many allies—poor men 730  
who talk about the riches they possess.  
They created discord in the city [590]  
and destroyed the state, because they wished  
to rob their neighbours, for the wealth they had  
in their own homes had disappeared, squandered  
by their idleness. Someone must have seen you  
entering the city. If anybody did,  
you must take care you do not unite them  
and get murdered when you least expect it.

HERAKLES

I do not care if the whole city saw me. 740  
But I glimpsed a bird in an inauspicious place  
and knew my family was in trouble.<sup>28</sup>  
So I stole into the city secretly.

AMPHITRYON

Good. Now go inside and greet the goddess  
of the hearth and home. Let your father's house [600]  
observe your face. The king will soon arrive  
in person to haul away your children  
and your wife. Then he will have them murdered.  
He will also slaughter me. If you stay here  
things will turn out well—and you will be safe. 750  
That should work to your advantage, too.  
But do not stir up trouble in the city,  
my son, until you have things well in hand.

HERAKLES

I will do that. What you advise is good.  
I will go in the house. After coming back  
from the sunless depths of the world below  
and queen Persephone, I will not fail  
to speak first to the gods beneath my roof.<sup>29</sup>

---

<sup>28</sup>In Greek literature, the flight and position of birds are often good or bad omens.

<sup>29</sup>Persephone is the wife of Hades (a brother of Zeus and Poseidon), king of the underworld.

HERAKLES

AMPHITRYON

My son, did you really go down to Hades? [610]

HERAKLES

Yes. And I carried that three-headed monster  
Cerberus back up into the daylight. 760

AMPHITRYON

Did you beat him in a fight, or get him  
from the goddess?

HERAKLES

It was in a fight.  
I had a chance to see the secret rites  
of the initiated.<sup>30</sup>

AMPHITRYON

And is that beast  
in Eurystheus's home?

HERAKLES

It is being held  
in the grove of Demeter in Hermione.

AMPHITRYON

Does Eurystheus know you have returned  
to the upper world?

HERAKLES

No. I came here first  
to find out what was going on.

AMPHITRYON

How is it  
you remained so long in the world below? 770

HERAKLES

I spent some time trying to get Theseus  
out of Hades.<sup>31</sup>

---

<sup>30</sup>Before entering Hades, Herakles (as a precaution) took part in a sacred religious rite known as the Eleusinian Mysteries, based on the myth of Demeter and her daughter Persephone. Those initiated in these mysteries were believed to find happiness in the underworld.

<sup>31</sup>Theseus, a legendary Athenian hero, went down to Hades with his comrade Pirithous to kidnap Persephone, the wife of Hades. Hades knew they were coming and trapped both of them. Theseus was rescued by Herakles.

## HERAKLES

AMPHITRYON

Where is he? Has he gone home, [620]  
back to his own land?

HERAKLES

He has gone to Athens,  
happy to have escaped the underworld.  
But come, my boys, accompany your father  
into the house. I suppose you are happier  
going in than you were when you came out.  
You must have courage, and stop those tears  
streaming from your eyes. You too, my lady, 780  
pull yourself together, stop your trembling.  
Let go of my clothes. I do not have wings,  
and I am not about to run away  
from those I love. Ah, they will not let go  
but hang onto my clothing even more.  
Were you all walking on a razor's edge? [630]  
I will take them by the hand and lead them,  
pulling them behind me, like a big ship  
towing little boats. I will not neglect  
the care of my own children. All people 790  
are in this respect the same—they love  
their children, whether they are better off  
or paupers. Money creates differences  
among them—some have it, some do not.  
But every human being loves his children.

*[Herakles, Amphytryon, Megara, and the children exit into the house, leaving the Chorus alone on stage.]*

CHORUS

I always loved the years when I was young,  
but old age now hangs heavy on my head,  
a burden weightier than Aetna's peak.<sup>32</sup> [640]  
Its darkness on my eyes conceals the light.  
I would never never trade my youthful years 800  
for all the wealth of Asia's kings or houses  
stuffed with gold. For rich and poor alike,  
the most glorious years are when we're young.  
I hate old age, a mournful, deadly time.  
I wish it would sink down beneath the waves [650]  
and never move into the homes and cities  
of mortal men or else be carried off,  
drifting away in the wind on wings.

---

<sup>32</sup>Mount Aetna is a volcano in Sicily.

## HERAKLES

If gods were intelligent and wise  
in how they dealt with human beings, 810  
they would have given men a second youth,  
a visible mark for those who have displayed [660]  
their human excellence. After they were dead,  
they would once more come back into the light  
and run a second course. The meanly born  
would only have one life. If this were done,  
we could all distinguish the good people  
from the bad, just as sailors recognize  
the number of the stars among the clouds.  
But now there is no useful boundary 820  
set by the gods between the good and bad, [670]  
and as the years roll by, the only thing  
that grows in power is human wealth.

I will not stop from blending into one  
that sweetest of all combinations—  
the Graces and the Muses.<sup>33</sup> I hope  
I never have to live without the Muses  
and will always be with those who wear  
garlands of honour and of great success.  
The ancient singer still celebrates 830  
his memories, and so I will still sing  
of gloriously triumphant Herakles, [680]  
as long as Bromius, giver of wine,  
is close to me, while seven-stringed lutes  
and Libyan flutes are still playing on.  
I will not stop singing the Muses' praise,  
for they are the ones who get me dancing.

The women of Delos sing their joyful song,  
as they circle around the temple gates,  
in honour of Leto's glorious son, 840  
the beautiful dancer.<sup>34</sup> So my old lips [690]  
will cry out at your palace doors  
my songs of joy, like a dying swan,  
for my subject is worthy of my praise—  
a son of Zeus whose noble birth  
is far surpassed by his glorious deeds.

---

<sup>33</sup>The Graces were goddesses of grace, charm, and beauty. There were three of them; Charis, Aglaea, and Thalia. The Muses were the goddesses of artistic and scientific achievement. There were nine of them: Calliope (epic poetry), Clio (history), Euterpe (music), Thalia (comedy and pastoral poetry), Melpomene (tragedy), Terpsichore (dance), Erato (lyric poetry), Polyhymnia (sacred poetry), Urania (astronomy). They were all daughters of Mnemosyne (goddess of memory).

<sup>34</sup>Leto's son is the god Apollo.

## HERAKLES

His labours have given mortal men  
a tranquil life, for he has removed  
so many monstrous and ferocious beasts. [700]

*[Enter Amphitryon from the house and Lycus and some attendants from the street.]*

LYCUS

It is time you finally left your house, 850  
Amphitryon. You have already taken  
far too long dressing yourself in robes  
and ornaments of the dead. But come now,  
tell Herakles's wife and children to come here,  
outside the house, and die in the manner  
you yourselves, of your own free will, proposed.

AMPHITRYON

My lord, you harass me in my misfortune  
and pile insults on me over my dead son.  
Though you rule in Thebes, you should moderate  
your eagerness to have us killed. But still, 860  
since you state my death is a necessity, [710]  
I must comply. We all must carry out  
whatever you think best.

LYCUS

Where is Megara?  
Where are the children of Alcmene's son?<sup>35</sup>

AMPHITRYON *[peering inside the doors of the house]*

It seems to me, as far as I can see,  
looking through this doorway, that she . . .

LYCUS *[interrupting]*

What do you think? Do you know for sure?

AMPHITRYON

. . . is sitting as a suppliant on the steps  
of Hestia's altar . . .

LYCUS *[interrupting]*

Imploring them in vain to save her life! 870

AMPHITRYON

And making futile cries to her dead husband.

---

<sup>35</sup>Alcmene was the mother of Herakles.

HERAKLES

LYCUS

He is not here, and he will never come.

AMPHITRYON

No.

Not unless some god wakes him from the dead.

LYCUS

Go to her, and bring her to the palace.

[720]

AMPHITRYON

If I do that, I would be helping you  
commit her murder.

LYCUS

If you have misgivings,  
I am not afraid to bring the mother out,  
together with her sons. Servants, follow me,  
so that we may happily bring this matter  
to its conclusion and then rest.

*[Lycus and his retinue go into the house.]*

AMPHITRYON

Go then.

880

Go and meet your fate. Someone else  
will probably take care of all the rest.  
Since you acted badly, you can expect  
to meet with bad things in return.

*[Amphitryon addresses the Chorus.]*

Old friends,  
it is good that he is going inside.  
He will get entangled in the meshes  
of a net of swords, while he is planning  
the slaughter of his neighbours, the monster!  
I will go in to watch him collapse and die,  
for the killing of one's enemy brings joy,  
when he is paying the price for his misdeeds.

[730]

890

*[Amphitryon goes in the house.]*

CHORUS

Evil has reversed its course—the man  
who was once a mighty leader has turned

## HERAKLES

his life away from Hades. Ah, justice  
and the recurring river of the gods!

Finally you have reached a place where death [740]  
will pay the penalty for the insolence  
you have shown towards your betters.

My joy has made me weep. He has come back!  
My heart never expected this to happen— 900  
the lord and master of this land!

### CHORUS

Come, old friends, we should look inside the house,  
to see if Herakles has fulfilled our hopes.

LYCUS [*from within*]

Help me! Help! [750]

### CHORUS

How I love to hear the start  
of that singing inside the house—his death  
is not far off. Our lord and master cries  
the prelude to his death.

LYCUS [*from within*]

O land of Thebes,  
I am being killed! Treason!

CHORUS [*speaking individually*]

You are a killer and must pay the price.  
Be brave and face your retribution now— 910  
punishment for the evil you have done.

Who was it that, although he was a mortal,  
foolishly abused the sacred heavenly gods  
by stupidly proclaiming they had no power?

Old friends, that godless man is now no more. [760]

The house is silent. We should turn to dancing.

My friends have been successful, as I hoped.

Dancing, dances, and more festivities  
will now take over Thebes, our sacred city.  
A change from tears, a change in fortune 920  
gives birth to brand new songs. Our recent king

## HERAKLES

has gone, our earlier king now rules.  
He left safe harbour down in Acheron, [770]  
and now our hopes have been fulfilled  
beyond our wildest dreams.<sup>36</sup>

The gods, the gods take care of the unjust  
and lend their ears to those who honour them.  
Good luck and gold can seduce men's hearts  
and bring on after them an unjust power.  
For no man ever has sufficient courage 930  
to think how time can change his fortune.  
And so, neglecting laws for lawlessness,  
he shatters the black chariot of success. [780]

O Ismenus, bedeck yourself with garlands!  
You cobbled streets, begin the choral dance  
in seven-gated Thebes. Come Dirce,  
loveliest of waters, you, too, you nymphs  
of Asopus, come from your father's stream,  
and lend your voices to our song in praise  
of the splendid victory of Herakles!<sup>37</sup> 940  
O tree-covered Pythian rock and home [790]  
of the Helicon Muses, you will come  
to my city of Thebes with shouts of joy,  
to my walls, where that race of men  
sown with the dragon's teeth sprang up,  
a warrior band with shields of brass,  
passing our land to children's children,  
a shining sacred light to Thebes.

O that marriage bed that two men shared,  
one mortal, the other Zeus himself, 950  
who came to have sex with the married bride, [800]  
Alcmene, grand-daughter of great Perseus.  
O Zeus, the story of your marriage then  
has in the past convinced me it is true,  
beyond all doubt, and time has shown  
the brilliant powers of Herakles,  
who left the halls of Pluto underground  
and returned through caverns in the earth below.  
For me you are a more righteous king  
than that low-born lord, who will now reveal, 960  
in this struggle of sword-bearing warriors,  
whether justice is still pleasing to the gods.

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<sup>36</sup>Acheron is a river in the underworld.

<sup>37</sup>Asopus is the name of a river god and a river.

## HERAKLES

*[Lyssa, goddess of madness, and Iris, the messenger of the gods, appear on the roof of the palace.]*

### CHORUS

My friends, look! Has a sense of fear and panic  
overcome us all? What kind of spirits  
am I looking at up there—above the house?

Run! Run! Hurry up! Get out of here!

O lord Apollo, protect us from all harm!

[820]

### IRIS

Take heart, old men! This person you see here  
is Lyssa, daughter of Night. I am Iris,  
handmaid of the gods. We have not come  
to harm your city. No. We come to fight  
the house of just one man, the one they call  
a son of Zeus delivered by Alcmene.  
Until he had completed all the tasks  
set by Eurystheus, his destiny  
protected him, and his father Zeus  
would not permit either Hera or myself  
to injure him. But now that he has finished  
all those onerous tasks, Hera wishes him  
to stain his hands once again with blood  
by killing his own sons. And I agree.  
Come then, unmarried daughter of black Night,  
harden your implacable heart. Drive madness  
into this man, disturb his mind, until  
he murders his own children, make his feet  
move uncontrollably, and goad him on.  
Unfurl the sails of slaughter so that he,  
after leading them across the Acheron,  
that beautiful group of children round him  
slain by his own hand, may understand  
just how much Hera is enraged at him,  
and learn my anger, too. If Herakles  
escapes this punishment, the gods will count  
for nothing, and mortals will be strong.

970

[830]

980

990

[840]

### LYSSA

I was born into a noble family,  
mother Night and the blood of Ouranos.<sup>38</sup>

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<sup>38</sup>Ouranos (meaning Sky) was one of the primal gods, along with Gaia (Earth). Night (Nyx) the personification of Night, was also a primordial god, born from Chaos.

## HERAKLES

I do not use the powers I possess  
if I am angry or annoyed with friends,  
nor am I fond of visiting the homes  
of those I like. So before I witness 1000  
goddess Hera making a mistake—  
and you, too, if you will pay attention  
to what I have to say—I wish to offer  
some advice. This man Herakles, the one  
whose home you are asking me to enter,  
is not unknown in heaven and on earth, [850]  
After taming the pathless wilderness  
and the raging sea, using his own strength  
he restored the honours of the gods,  
when they were being attacked by godless men.<sup>39</sup> 1010  
So I would advise you not to wish on him  
such a huge disaster.

IRIS

There is no need  
for your advice on what Hera and I  
may well be scheming.

LYSSA

I am guiding your steps  
towards a more desirable pathway  
than the evil one you seek.

IRIS

The wife of Zeus  
did not send you here to act with prudence.

LYSSA

I call on sun god Helios to witness  
that I am doing this against my will.  
But if I truly am being forced to help 1020  
you and Hera—and with all speed, like a pack [860]  
of noisy hounds following the hunter—  
then I will go. Neither the angry sea  
with its howling waves nor an earthquake  
nor an agonizing blast of lightning  
will be like the frantic assault I launch  
into Herakles's chest. I will smash  
his roof apart and then move through the house.  
First, I kill the sons. The man who slays them

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<sup>39</sup>There appears to be a small gap in the manuscript here.

## HERAKLES

will not know that he is slaughtering 1030  
children he begot, not until I lift  
my fit of madness. Just look at him!  
This is how it starts—with his head tossing,  
the fierce distorted pupils in his eyes  
rolling back and forth, in complete silence.  
He is breathing faster, like a fierce bull  
about to charge. He bellows, calling out [870]  
to the goddesses of death in Tartarus.<sup>40</sup>  
Soon I will have you dancing—I will play  
music of terror on my flute. So Iris, 1040  
you can be on your noble way, soaring  
up to Olympus, while I, in secret,  
will slither into Herakles's palace.

### CHORUS

Alas, alas! We must all lament  
the son of Zeus, the flower of our city.  
Unhappy Hellas, you will thrust him out,  
the one who did you so much good,  
and demolish him as he is dancing  
to the flutes in Lyssa's frantic madness.

The Gorgon child of Night is climbing 1050 [880]  
up into her chariot, queen of grief,  
with a hundred heads of serpents hissing  
in her hair, madness gleaming in her eyes,  
and, as if outraged, is goading her team on.

She quickly changes his good fortune—  
soon his children will breathe no more,  
all slaughtered by their father's hand.

AMPHITRYON [*from within the palace*]  
Alas! It's horrible!

### CHORUS

O Zeus, mad and unjust Vengeance,  
who eats raw meat, will soon overwhelm 1060  
with misery your childless child. [890]

AMPHITRYON [*from within*]  
Alas for this house!

---

<sup>40</sup>Tartarus is the lowest part of Hades.

## HERAKLES

### CHORUS

The dance begins without a kettledrum,  
no joyful waving of the Bacchic wand.<sup>41</sup>

### AMPHITRYON [*from within*]

Alas for this home!

### CHORUS

Libations now will be of blood  
and not with Dionysian wine.

### AMPHITRYON [*from within*]

You children, run! Hurry!

### CHORUS

That is death—death music of the flute.  
Now the hunter is chasing the children.  
Lyssa will never leave her frenzied dance  
inside this house until her wishes are fulfilled.

1070

### AMPHITRYON [*from within*]

Alas, the monstrous evil . . .

[900]

### CHORUS

Alas, I mourn for the ancient father  
and the mother, too, who bore his sons,  
and all in vain. Look! Look! A storm wind  
shakes the house! The roof is falling in!

### HERAKLES [*from within*]

O Pallas, child of Zeus, what are you doing  
to this home? You are sending the havoc  
of Tartarus against my house, as you did  
with Enceladus years ago.<sup>42</sup>

1080

[*A messenger enters from the palace.*]

### MESSENGER

You there, you white-haired old men!

### CHORUS

Why that loud shout?  
Are you addressing me?

[910]

<sup>41</sup>The Bacchic wand is called the thyrsus. It is the stalk of a plant, used in the frantic dances of the worshippers of Bacchus, where it can sometimes acquire magical powers.

<sup>42</sup>Pallas is another name for Athena. Enceladus was one of the Giants who attacked the Olympian gods in an effort to take over mount Olympus. He was particularly hostile to Athena.

## HERAKLES

MESSENGER

Inside the house there . . .  
it's horrific!

CHORUS

I don't need another prophet  
to tell me that.

MESSENGER

The children are dead.

CHORUS

Alas!

MESSENGER

You must weep. What has happened here  
calls for a lament.

CHORUS

A dreadful slaughter!  
Their parent's savage hands!

MESSENGER

What we have suffered  
is beyond what any man can tell.

CHORUS

How did it happen—this disaster  
with the children, the disaster  
brought about by their own father.  
Tell me how this catastrophe sent  
from the gods attacked this home and brought  
such ruinous fate upon the children.

1090

[920]

MESSENGER

After Herakles had slaughtered Lycus,  
master of this land, and thrown the body  
out of the house, sacrificial offerings  
were placed before the altar of great Zeus,  
to purify the home. His lovely boys  
stood in a cluster with Amphytrion,  
his father, and Megara. The basket  
was by now being passed around the altar,  
and we were all observing holy silence.  
Herakles was about to bring the torch  
in his right hand and dip it in the basin.

1100

## HERAKLES

He stood there in silence. As he waited, [930]  
 the three children looked up at their father.  
 He was not himself. He was in distress—  
 eyes rolling, eyeballs bloodshot, and spit 1110  
 oozing down his bearded chin. Then he spoke  
 with a maniacal laugh: “Why, father,  
 should I offer purifying fire now,  
 before I have murdered Eurystheus?  
 This way I will have to cleanse the palace  
 twice over, when my hands can do the work  
 a single time—and do it properly.  
 Once I bring the head of Eurystheus here,  
 I will cleanse my hands for these dead bodies, [940]  
 the ones already killed. Pour out the water. 1120  
 Drop the baskets. Who will fetch my bow?  
 And a weapon for my hand? I will march  
 to Mycenae! I need to carry crowbars,  
 and iron picks, so I can shatter once again  
 those foundations built by the Cyclopes  
 with mason’s tools and Phoenician plumb-lines.”  
 Then he went out. There was no chariot there,  
 though he claimed there was. He tried to climb up,  
 with his fist clenched, as if he held a whip,  
 but in reality there was nothing there. 1130  
 His servants were of two minds—they found him [950]  
 ridiculous, but were afraid, as well.  
 One of them, looking at another, asked,  
 “Is our master just having fun with us,  
 or has he gone insane?” But Herakles  
 was pacing up and down inside the house.  
 Rushing to the middle of the men’s apartments,  
 he said that he had reached the town of Nisus,  
 although he was still walking in his home.  
 Then he lay down on the floor, just as he was, 1140  
 prepared to have a feast. After a while,  
 he said he was travelling to the flat lands  
 in the wooded valleys of the Isthmus.<sup>43</sup>  
 Then he stripped the clothing from his body  
 and, quite naked, began to wrestle someone  
 who was not there, and just like a herald, [960]  
 he proclaimed himself the glorious victor,  
 but he had no audience. Next he thought  
 he was in Mycenae, roaring dire threats  
 at Eurystheus. His father grabbed hold 1150  
 of Herakles’s powerful arm and said,

---

<sup>43</sup>The Isthmus is the narrow piece of land joining mainland Greece with the Peloponnese.

## HERAKLES

“My son, what is the matter with you?  
Why these strange goings on? Surely the blood  
of those whom you just killed has not made you  
lose you mind?” But Herakles, assuming  
it was the father of Eurystheus  
attempting in a craven supplication  
to touch his hand, pushed Amphitryon away  
and got his bow and arrows ready, prepared  
to shoot his children—he believed they were  
the sons of Eurystheus. The young boys,  
panic stricken, ran in terror here and there—  
one to his poor mother’s robes, another  
to the shadow of a pillar, and the third  
crouched down beneath the altar, like a bird.  
Their mother screamed, “You are their father—  
what are you doing? Killing your own sons?”  
The old man and the servants kept on shouting.  
Herakles was moving round the pillar,  
in murderous circles, chasing his son.  
When they came face to face, he killed the boy  
with an arrow through his heart. The lad fell  
on his back, spraying the stone pillars  
with his blood, as he choked his life away.  
Herakles cried out in triumph and boasted,  
“One of Eurystheus’s chicks lies dead,  
here at my feet, payment for the hatred  
his father showed.” Then he turned his bow  
against another son, who had crouched down  
by the altar’s foundation stone, thinking  
he might not be observed. Before he shot,  
his poor son sprang up and threw himself  
at his father’s knees and, raising his hand  
towards his father’s beard and neck, cried out,  
“Listen, dear father, and do not kill me!  
I am your child, your son! You are not slaying  
a son of Eurystheus!” But Herakles,  
rolled his savage Gorgon eyes, and, since the boy  
was standing too close for him to let loose  
a lethal arrow, he hit him on the head.  
Just as a blacksmith pounds the red-hot iron,  
so Herakles used his wooden club to strike  
his fair-haired son and pulverize his skull.  
Having killed his second son, he moved on  
to add a third corpse to the other two.  
Before he could, the desperate mother  
picked up the child, ran inside the house,  
and barred the door. So Herakles, as if

1160 [970]

1170

[980]

1180

[990]

1190

## HERAKLES

he was at walls built by the Cyclopes,  
dug out the doors with levers, knocked down 1200  
the doorposts, and with a single arrow [1000]  
killed his wife and son. Then he races off  
to murder his old father, Amphytrion.  
But a phantom came—to those who watched  
it looked like Pallas in a plumed helmet,  
waving a spear. She threw a rock at him  
and hit Herakles in the chest. That blow  
halted his frenzied blood-lust and put him  
into a deep sleep. He fell to the ground,  
hitting his back on a pillar which had fallen 1210  
and broken in two when the roof collapsed.  
At that point we stopped trying to flee, [1010]  
and, with the old man's help, we tied him up,  
lashing him to the pillar with cords and knots,  
so that when he wakes up, he will commit  
no more atrocities. The poor man is asleep.  
After the slaughter of his wife and children,  
that sleep of his will not be truly blessed.  
I know no man more miserable than he.

*[Exit the Messenger.]*

### CHORUS

The murders committed by the daughters 1220  
of Danaus on the rock of Argolis  
were once the most famous and amazing  
in all of Hellas, but this business here  
with Herakles, the unhappy son of Zeus,  
has overtaken and surpassed those killings [1020]  
from many years ago.<sup>44</sup>

I will mention  
that murder carried out by Procne,  
a mother who had a single child.  
She sacrificed him to the Muses.<sup>45</sup>  
But you were father of three boys, 1230  
you wretched man, and in your madness  
you assisted fate and killed them all.

---

<sup>44</sup>The Daughters of Danaus were a group of fifty women who were compelled to marry their first cousins. On the wedding night all the daughters but one, acting on the order of their father, murdered their husbands. For this murder the daughters were punished in Hades.

<sup>45</sup>Procne killed her son Itys, cooked him, and fed him to his father, Tereus, for dinner. She did this in revenge for Tereus raping, maiming, and imprisoning her sister Philomena.

## HERAKLES

Alas! What groans, tears, songs for the dead,  
or dance of death do I now use to grieve?

Look! The locked gates of the high-roofed palace  
are being pulled open. [1030]

*[The front doors of the palace open slowly, revealing the corpses of Megara and the three children. Herakles is still sleeping and tied with ropes to the pillar.]*

Alas! Look at that.  
Those poor children just lying there  
in front of their unhappy father,  
who, after slaughtering them, has fallen  
into a fearful sleep.

The ropes  
and all those knots around his body  
are supporting Herakles and keeping him  
lashed to the stone pillar from his home. 1240

### CHORUS

His old father, like a bird lamenting  
the birth pains from her featherless brood,  
is rushing here with shuffling, painful steps.  
Here he comes. [1040]

*[Enter Amphytryon from the palace.]*

### AMPHYTRYON

Quietly, quietly,  
you old citizens of Thebes. Can you not  
let him continue sleeping, unaware  
of the dreadful killings he has done? 1250

### CHORUS LEADER

I mourn for you with my tears, old friend,  
and for the children and that splendid man.

### AMPHYTRYON

Move further off, and do not make a noise.  
Do not shout or wake him from his peaceful sleep. [1050]

### CHORUS

Alas! All this blood . . .

HERAKLES

AMPHITRYON

Be quiet!

You'll be the death of me!

CHORUS

. . . that he has shed  
is rising up . . .

AMPHITRYON

Old friends, can you not whisper  
your lament? If not, he may wake up,  
throw off his restraints, destroy the city  
and his father, and tear apart his home.

1260

CHORUS

I cannot do that—it is not possible!

AMPHITRYON

Be quiet! I will check his breathing.  
Come, let me listen!

[1060]

CHORUS

Is he sleeping?

AMPHITRYON

Yes, he is having a dreadful sleepless sleep,  
after using his quivering bowstring  
and arrows to kill his wife and sons.

CHORUS

Now is the time to mourn.

AMPHITRYON

I am mourning!

CHORUS

The death of those children . . .

AMPHITRYON

Alas!

CHORUS

I lament for your son, too.

AMPHITRYON

Aaaiiii.

## HERAKLES

### CHORUS

My old friend . . .

### AMPHITRYON

Hush! Silence!

1270

He is turning over. . . . He is stirring . . .  
and waking up. I should conceal myself  
somewhere in the ruins of this roof.

[1070]

### CHORUS

Do not worry. Darkness is still holding down  
the eyelids of your son.

### AMPHITRYON

Look, given my misery  
I have no fear of departing from the light,  
but if he were to kill me, his own father,  
he would be heaping evil onto evil,  
adding parent's blood to the Furies' curse.<sup>46</sup>

### CHORUS

It would be better for you if you had died  
when you set off seeking your revenge  
for the murdered brothers of your wife  
and sacked the island city of the Taphians.

1280

[1080]

### AMPHITRYON

You must leave, old friends. Get away from here—  
from the front part of the palace. Herakles  
is waking up—you must escape his fury,  
or he will quickly pile one more killing  
on the others, or he might set off  
on a frenzied rampage through the city.

### CHORUS

O Zeus, why do you detest your son so much?  
Why hurl him into this sea of evil?  
Why so much savage brutality?

1290

### HERAKLES [*waking up*]

Ah, I am breathing, and my eyes can see  
what they should be seeing—the sky, the earth,  
the rays of sunlight . . . but my mind is reeling,  
plunged into terrible confusion. My breath

[1090]

---

<sup>46</sup>The Furies were the goddesses of blood revenge, especially within the family.

## HERAKLES

is feverish and quick and issues from my lungs  
in spasms.

*[Herakles looks around him.]*

What is this? What am I doing  
lying here with my youthful chest and arms  
tied down with rope, like a ship at anchor, 1300  
beside a broken pillar, with corpses  
next to where I sit? My bow and arrows,  
lie scattered on the floor, trusty weapons  
I carried into battle on my arm.  
They took care of me, I took care of them. [1100]  
Surely I have not come back again to Hades—  
a second trip for Eurystheus? To Hades?  
From where? But I do not see Sisyphus  
or his rock, or Pluto, or the sceptre  
of Demeter's daughter, Persephone.<sup>47</sup> 1310  
I am totally confused. Where am I?  
Why am I so helpless? Hey, you there,  
are any of my friends around—close by  
or far away—who can cure my ignorance?  
For I lack any clear idea of things  
that used to be familiar.

AMPHITRYON

Old friends,  
should I get closer and risk being killed?

CHORUS LEADER

All right. I'll go with you. I will not leave, [1100]  
if you get into trouble.

HERAKLES

Why weep, father?  
Why hide your eyes, and keep your distance 1320  
from your beloved son?

AMPHITRYON

O my child!  
You are still my son, in spite of all the evil  
you have done.

---

<sup>47</sup>Sisyphus was a man eternally punished in Hades by having to roll a large rock up a hill. Every time he got the rock close to the top, it would roll down to the bottom, and Sisyphus would have to start again. Demeter was a goddess whose daughter Persephone married Hades, king of the underworld.

## HERAKLES

HERAKLES

What have I done that is so bad  
it has made you weep?

AMPHITRYON

What you have done  
would make any of the gods weep with sorrow,  
if he learned about it.

HERAKLES

You have made  
a grand statement, without mentioning  
what happened.

AMPHITRYON

You can see it for yourself,  
if by now you have regained your senses.

HERAKLES

If in my life I am being accused  
of something new, then tell me.

1330

AMPHITRYON

I will tell you, if you no longer are  
a frenzied maniac from hell.

HERAKLES

Ah ha!  
Your dark words are arousing my suspicions.

[1120]

AMPHITRYON

And I still wish to see whether your mind  
is steady and working as it should.

HERAKLES

I have no memory of being mad.

AMPHITRYON

Friends, do you think I should untie my son?  
What should I do?

HERAKLES

You should untie me.  
And tell me who bound me up. I feel ashamed.

1340

AMPHITRYON

You know enough concerning your misfortune.

HERAKLES

Let the rest all go.

HERAKLES

No. If I stay silent,  
is that enough to find out what I wish to know?

AMPHITRYON

O Zeus, are you witnessing these things  
that have their origin at Hera's throne?

HERAKLES

Has Hera's hostility caused my suffering?

AMPHITRYON

Let the goddess go! You need to confront  
your own misfortunes.

HERAKLES

I am done for.  
You are going to talk of some calamity. [1130]

AMPHITRYON

Look. These are the bodies of your children. 1350

HERAKLES

This is horrific . . . what am I looking at?  
Aaaiii! An appalling sight!

AMPHITRYON

My son, you launched  
a one-sided war against your children.

HERAKLES

What are you talking about? What war?  
Who killed these boys?

AMPHITRYON

You did—  
you, your bow, and some god are responsible.

HERAKLES

What are you telling me? What did I do?  
You are a bringer of disastrous news!

AMPHITRYON

You were in a mad fit. Now you want me  
to tell you something horrible. 1360

HERAKLES

HERAKLES

And did I also slaughter my own wife?

AMPHITRYON

All this killing was done by your own hand.  
You had no help.

HERAKLES

Alas! I am now caged in  
by a cloud of grief.

[1140]

AMPHITRYON

That is the reason  
I lament your fate.

HERAKLES

In my mad frenzy,  
did I destroy my home?

AMPHITRYON

All I know is this—  
you are completely ruined.

HERAKLES

This madness—  
where was I when it came over me?  
Where did it demolish me?

AMPHITRYON

At the altar—  
you were purifying your hands with fire.

1370

HERAKLES

Alas! Why do I not just end my life,  
when I am the killer of my own dear sons?  
Should I not go and leap from some tall cliff,  
or plunge my sword into my heart and avenge  
my children's blood, or else throw my body,  
which was driven insane, into the fire,  
and thus avoid living with the infamy  
which now awaits me?

[1150]

*[Herakles sees Theseus and his attendants approaching.]*

But now,  
to interrupt these thoughts of death, I see

## HERAKLES

king Theseus approaching—my kinsman  
and my friend. I shall be seen for what I am.  
My dearest friend will see I am unclean,  
polluted by the murder of my sons.  
This is dreadful. What am I going to do?  
Where can I find freedom from this evil?  
Shall I grow wings or plunge into the earth?  
Come, I will conceal my head in darkness.  
What I have done makes me so ashamed. [1160]  
For these blood killings I am now defiled,  
and I do not wish to harm the innocent. 1390

*[Enter Theseus and his armed attendants.]*

### THESEUS

I have come, old friend, and others with me,  
young fighting lads from the land of Athens,  
now waiting by the river Asopus,  
bringing allied spears to assist your son.  
For in the city of the Erechtheidae  
a rumour spread that Lycus had usurped  
the royal sceptre in the land of Thebes  
and was now fighting or waging war  
against you.<sup>48</sup> So I came here, to pay back  
Herakles for the way he rescued me 1400  
from the underworld—that is, old man,  
if you need help from my allies and me. [1170]

*[Theseus notices the dead bodies of the children and Megara.]*

What is this? Why is there a pile of corpses  
on the floor? Surely I did not leave home  
and arrive too late to stop a new disaster?  
Who killed these children? Whose wife is this?  
Young boys do not fight battles with their spears.  
No, I have stumbled on some fresh atrocity.

### AMPHITRYON

O king living on that hill where olives grow!

### THESEUS

Why greet me with such a melancholy tone? 1410

### AMPHITRYON

The gods have made us suffer a catastrophe. [1180]

---

<sup>48</sup>The city of the Erechtheidae (literally “the sons of Erechtheus”) is Athens.

## HERAKLES

THESEUS

You are weeping for these murdered children.  
Whose are they?

AMPHITRYON

They are my own son's children,  
the poor man. He was their father  
and he butchered them—after steeling his heart  
to carry out the bloody slaughter.

THESEUS

You should speak of this more gently.

AMPHITRYON

I wish I could do what you are asking.

THESEUS

You have spoken of appalling things.

AMPHITRYON

We are done for, ruined.

THESEUS

What do you mean?  
What has Herakles done?

1420

AMPHITRYON

He was caught up in a fit of madness  
and used arrows dipped in lethal venom  
from the hundred-headed hydra.

[1190]

THESEUS

Hera  
had her hand in this. But who is that,  
old friend, sitting among the corpses?

AMPHITRYON

That is my son, my much-enduring son,  
who marched with the gods to Phlegra plain,  
a warrior, whose weapons did battle with  
and killed the giants.

THESEUS

Ah, yes. What man was ever born  
with such an ill-starred fate?

1430

## HERAKLES

AMPHITRYON

You will not find  
another mortal man who has suffered more  
and wandered further.

THESEUS

Why is the poor man  
using his clothes to hide his head?

AMPHITRYON

From shame.  
He does not want your eyes to look at him  
covered with blood from his slaughtered sons, [1200]  
especially you, a friend and relative.

THESEUS

But I have come to sympathize with him.  
Uncover his head.

AMPHITRYON

My son, uncover your eyes.  
Push your clothes aside. Let sun see your face. 1440  
As someone who is wrestling with grief  
and trying to stem my tears, I beg you,  
as a suppliant, reaching for your beard,  
your knee, and arm, and prostrate before you,  
shedding an old man's tear—O my child, [1210]  
curb that wild lion's spirit in your chest,  
which leads you down a bloody, godless path,  
eager to stack one evil on another.

THESEUS [*moving closer to Herakles*]

All right. I am talking to you in there,  
hunched up in misery. Show us your face. 1450  
We are friends, and there is no darkness  
black enough to conceal your wretched mood.  
Why are you waving your hand at me?  
Are you telling me that this is murder  
and that I should not talk at all to you  
in case I get polluted? I do not care [1220]  
if I fall into misfortune with you—  
with you I once enjoyed good fortune,  
and I must mention that. It was the time  
you rescued me from the land of the dead 1460  
and brought me back into the light of day.<sup>49</sup>

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<sup>49</sup>See above, line 770 ff.

HERAKLES

I detest a friend whose gratitude grows old—  
someone eager to enjoy his friend's success,  
but unwilling to share the same ship with him  
when his friend's fortune changes for the worse.  
So stand up. Uncover your wretched head.  
And look at me. Among human beings,  
the nobly born accept calamities  
sent by the gods and do not disown them.

*[Herakles uncovers his head and stands up.]*

HERAKLES

Theseus, did you see how my sons struggled?

1470

THESEUS

I heard about that, and now I can see  
the atrocity you mean.

[1230]

HERAKLES

Why then  
have you exposed my head to sunlight?

THESEUS

Why not? You are a mortal human being—  
you cannot contaminate what is divine.

HERAKLES

You should run away, you poor man, from me  
and the stain of my pollution.

THESEUS

There is no avenging spirit which goes  
from one friend to another.

HERAKLES

Yes, that is true.  
And I am not ashamed I helped you out.

1480

THESEUS

Because you were so kind to me back then,  
I feel compassion for you now.

HERAKLES

A pitiful wretch,  
that is what I am—the killer of my sons.

## HERAKLES

THESEUS

I weep for you and for your change in fortune.

HERAKLES

Have you ever found any other man bearing greater hardships?

THESEUS

Your misfortunes [1240]  
 reach from earth right up to heaven.

HERAKLES

That is why  
I am making preparations for my death.

THESEUS

Do you think divine beings really care  
about the threatening words you utter?

HERAKLES

The gods have been remorseless to me,  
so I will be the same with them.

THESEUS

Hold you tongue—  
in case they make your suffering more painful  
for speaking out with such presumption.

HERAKLES

I am so full of troubles there is room  
for nothing more.

THESEUS

So what will you do?  
Where are your emotions taking you?

HERAKLES

To die and go beneath the earth, the place  
where I just came from.

THESEUS

Now you are talking  
like any common ordinary man.

HERAKLES

You offer me advice, but you are one who is not suffering misfortune.

HERAKLES

THESEUS

Is this the much-enduring Herakles  
speaking to me? [1250]

HERAKLES

But not this much!  
There must be limits to what one has to bear.

THESEUS

Is this the benefactor and great friend to man?

HERAKLES

Mortals are no help to me. Hera has won.

THESEUS

Greece would not let you die so stupidly.

HERAKLES

You should listen now to what I have to say  
in contesting your advice. I will show you  
how my life, now and in the past, has been  
intolerable for me. First, my father,  
before he married my mother, Alcmene,  
murdered her old father—and thus acquired  
the stain of blood pollution, and any race  
with a poorly laid foundation must produce  
descendants who are cursed by the same stain.<sup>50</sup>  
Now Zeus, whoever Zeus may be, fathered me  
as an enemy to Hera.

1510 [1260]

*[Turning to address Amphitryon.]*

Old man,  
do not be upset, for I consider you,  
not Zeus, my father.

1520

*[Herakles turns back to Theseus.]*

While I was still an infant  
being suckled, Zeus's wife tried to kill me  
by dropping some dreadful venomous snakes  
inside my cradle. Once I had matured  
into my prime of youth, I had to bear  
all sorts of hardships. But what is the point  
of mentioning them now—all those lions,

[1270]

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<sup>50</sup>Alcmene's father was Electryon, who was killed accidentally by Amphitryon. See line 22 and the accompanying footnote.

## HERAKLES

and triple-bodied Typhons, or Giants,  
 or that war against four-legged Centaurs?  
 Did I not prevail against them all? I killed  
 1530 the hydra, that monster with many heads,  
 each one of which could grow in place again,  
 and then completed countless other tasks.  
 Carrying out what Eurystheus ordered,  
 I reached the land of the dead to bring back  
 into the sunlight the three-headed hound  
 that guards the gates of Hades. And lastly,  
 to my sorrow, I undertook this labour—  
 to complete the misery in my home  
 1540 by murdering my sons. Necessity  
 has brought me to this point. I cannot live  
 in my beloved Thebes. For piety  
 makes that impossible. If I did stay,  
 to what temple or gathering of friends  
 could I still go? The curse I bear makes me  
 a pariah. Should I go to Argos?  
 How can I do that, when I am exiled  
 from my native land? So come on, tell me,  
 is there some other place that I can run to?  
 Once people know that I am Herakles,  
 1550 they will scowl at me and keep me constrained  
 with bitter piercing tongues, “Is not this man  
 the son of Zeus who once killed all his children  
 and his wife? Should he not be forced to leave  
 1560 our city?” To someone who was once called blessed,  
 such changes are distressing. To a person  
 who has always had bad luck, these issues  
 cause no pain, for he was born to suffer.  
 I think that one day I will reach a point  
 where the earth will call out, forbidding me  
 to touch her, and the seas and river springs  
 will not let me across. I shall end up  
 just like another Ixion, in chains  
 on a revolving wheel.<sup>51</sup> It would be best  
 if I was never seen by any Greeks,  
 with whom in better days I have been happy.  
 1570 Why then should I live? What profit is there  
 in having a useless and unholy life?  
 So let that celebrated wife of Zeus dance,  
 her shoes striking the floor of Zeus’s palace.  
 She has achieved her goal, to overturn

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<sup>51</sup>Ixion was eternally punished by Zeus (for having designs on Zeus’s wife, Hera) by being bound to a fiery rotating wheel in Hades.

## HERAKLES

the finest man in Greece and leave him stripped  
to his foundations. Who would offer prayers  
to such a goddess? Zeus loved a woman,  
and, because of that, Hera's jealousy  
has crushed a man who was quite innocent, [1310]  
and who has benefited Greece.

### CHORUS

This whole matter  
is not the work of any other god  
but Hera, Zeus's wife. You were correct  
in that assumption.

### THESEUS

[To give advice to others 1580  
is easier than suffering misfortune.]<sup>52</sup>  
No mortal man remains completely free  
of misfortune's stain—nor does any god,  
if what poets sing is not mere fiction.  
Have they not made love with one another  
in ways no laws permit? Have they not  
bound their fathers up in chains to gain control?<sup>53</sup>  
And yet they still inhabit mount Olympus  
and exalt what they did wrong. As for you,  
a mortal human being, what will you say 1590 [1320]  
if you find your fate too difficult to bear  
while the gods do not? Get away from Thebes,  
as the law requires, and then follow me  
to Athens, Athena's city. Once there,  
I will cleanse your hands of all pollution,  
and give you homes, a share in what I own,  
and all the gifts I got from citizens  
for saving fourteen children, when I killed  
that bull in Knossos.<sup>54</sup> Throughout my country  
I have lands officially assigned to me. 1600  
From now on, these will be named after you, [1330]  
for as long as you still live. When you die

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<sup>52</sup>The Greek for this sentence is unclear (some of it is evidently missing). I have borrowed the suggested translation for these lines from R. Potter's translation (adapted by Mary Ebbott and Casey Dué). <https://www.uh.edu/~cldue/texts/herakles.html>.

<sup>53</sup>Zeus fought his father Cronos and chained him up deep in Tartarus in order to gain control of heaven.

<sup>54</sup>King Minos of Crete demanded a tribute from Athens every nine years of seven young men and seven young women. These children he fed to the Minotaur, a creature that was part man and part bull, which Minos kept in a labyrinth. Theseus was chosen as one of these tribute Athenians. With the help of Ariadne, Minos's daughter, he entered the labyrinth, killed the Minotaur, and left Knossos, taking Ariadne with him.

## HERAKLES

and move to Hades' home, all of Athens,  
the entire city, will celebrate your worth  
with sacrifices and a monument  
made of stone. All of Hellas will award  
my citizens the magnificent crown  
of a noble reputation, for they helped  
a good and noble man. I am doing this  
as a favour to you, to pay you back  
for saving me. For now you need a friend.  
When a god holds a man in honour  
he has no need of friends—the god's help,  
when he decides to act, is quite enough.

1610

## HERAKLES

Well, all such matters dealing with the gods  
do not have much bearing on my ordeals.  
As far as I'm concerned, I do not believe  
the gods make love in ways that are not right,  
and I have never thought that chaining up  
the hands of other gods was plausible,  
so you will not persuade me of that now.  
Nor do I believe that one god is born  
lord and master of another. A god,  
if he is, in fact, truly a deity,  
stands in need of nothing. Such stories  
are wretched tales made up by our poets.  
However, though I am plagued with troubles,  
I have considered whether quitting life  
would label me a coward. For any man  
who cannot hold out against ill fortune  
will not be capable of standing up  
against an enemy's arrow. So I  
will persevere with living. I will go  
to your city, with grateful thanks to you  
for your countless gifts. I have had a taste  
of a thousand different tasks. Not once  
have I refused or ever had my eyes  
shed a single tear. And I did not think  
I would ever come to this—tears flowing  
from my eyes. But if nowadays it seems  
I must be slave to fortune, so be it.

[1340]

1620

1630

[1350]

1640

*[Herakles turns his attention to Amphytrion.]*

Old friend, you see me leaving here an exile,  
and you see in me the one who murdered  
my own sons. Give them a proper burial.

## HERAKLES

Lay out their bodies. Honour them with tears— [1360]  
the law does not allow me to perform that rite.  
Lean them on their mother's breast and place them  
in her folded arms, a melancholy group,  
which I, alas, destroyed against my will.  
When you have hidden the bodies in the earth, 1650  
stay in the city, though that may be hard.  
Steel your heart to help me bear my suffering.  
O my sons, the man who gave you your lives,  
your father, has destroyed you. No benefits  
will come to you from what I have achieved  
with my own strength, the brutal toil to win  
a glorious name for you, a splendid gift [1370]  
a father leaves his sons. And you, as well,  
my sad wife, whom I killed, a poor reward  
for your steadfast loyalty in honouring 1660  
our marriage bed and your long, tiring care  
inside our home. Alas, for my wife and sons,  
alas for me, how dreadful were those acts  
that left me without my wife and children!

*[Herakles kisses the bodies of Megara and the children.]*

O those kisses you enjoyed, so bitter now!  
How bitter, too, to still have these weapons.  
I am not sure whether I should keep them  
or just let them go. If they are hanging  
at my side, they will say, "With us you killed [1380]  
your children and your wife. When you hold us, 1670  
you are clasping your children's murderers."  
If I am still carrying them on my arm,  
what answer do I give? But should I remove  
these weapons with which I have achieved  
such splendid things in Greece, leaving myself  
at the mercy of my enemies, and die  
a shameful death? No. I will not let them go.  
I will keep them, although that makes me sad.  
But Theseus, I need your help with something—  
that wretched hell hound Cerberus.<sup>55</sup> Come with me 1680  
to Argos, help me to collect the payment  
for bringing that beast back. If I go alone,  
I may come to grief thinking of my sons.  
O land of Cadmus, and all you citizens  
of Thebes, cut off your hair, grieve together.

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<sup>55</sup>Fetching Cerberus, the monster dog guarding the entrance to Hades, back to Argos was Herakles's final labour for Eurystheus.

HERAKLES

Go to my children's burial site and sing  
a lament for the departed and for me.  
All of us have been utterly demolished  
by one vicious, murderous blow from Hera.

THESEUS

Get up, you poor man. You have wept enough.

1690

HERAKLES

I cannot stand up. My knees are aching.

THESEUS

Misfortune weakens even the powerful.

HERAKLES

How I wish I could turn into a stone,  
with no memory of evil.

THESEUS

Stop that.

Give your hand to a friend who wants to help.

HERAKLES

I do not wish to stain your clothes with blood.

THESEUS

Do not worry. Let it stain my clothes.  
I am not ashamed.

[1400]

HERAKLES

I have lost my sons,  
but in you I have found a son.

THESEUS

Lift your arm  
around my neck. I'll show you the way.

1700

HERAKLES

A pair of friends, one of them unlucky.

*[To Amphitryon]*

Ah, old friend, this is the kind of man  
one ought to make a friend.

HERAKLES

AMPHITRYON

May the land  
that gave him birth be blessed with children!  
HERAKLES

Theseus,  
turn me around again, so I can see my sons.

THESEUS

Why? Is this some kind of soothing potion?

HERAKLES

I wish it were. I want to hug my father.

AMPHITRYON

Here I am, my son. I would like that, too.

THESEUS

Do you no longer have any memories  
of all your labours? [1410]

HERAKLES

All those hardships I endured  
brought me less grief than this. 1710

THESEUS

If people see you  
acting like a woman, they will not be pleased.

HERAKLES

Do you think that I, by choosing to live,  
have now become an ordinary man?  
That was not the case before, it seems.

THESEUS

Yes, very much so. You have a sickness  
and are not the glorious Herakles.

HERAKLES

What kind of man were you down there  
when you were in trouble?

THESEUS

I had less courage  
than any other man.

HERAKLES

HERAKLES

How then can you claim  
that my misfortunes have demeaned me.

1720

THESEUS

Let us set off.

HERAKLES [*to Amphitryon*]

Farewell, old friend.

AMPHITRYON

Farewell to you, my son.

HERAKLES

Bury my children as I have described.

AMPHITRYON

But who will bury me, my son?

HERAKLES

I will.

[1420]

AMPHITRYON

When will you come?

HERAKLES

When you have buried all my sons.

AMPHITRYON

How?

HERAKLES

I will have you brought from Thebes to Athens.  
But carry the children inside the house—  
they are a grievous burden on the earth.  
After shattering my home with shameful acts,  
I, now ruined, will follow Theseus  
like some useless, burdensome appendage.  
Whoever wishes to have power and wealth  
rather than good friends, is not thinking right.

1730

[*Exit Theseus, Herakles, and attendants.*]

CHORUS

With pity and many tears, we go away,  
lamenting the loss of our greatest friend.

HERAKLES

*[Exit the Chorus.]*